

How to Tackle an OBSTINATE PAKISTAN?

BEST experts advise a multi-pronged strategy to deal with Pakistan. Resume a limited dialogue, they say, but do not shy away from a tough approach to minimise the terror threat.

Amitabh Mattoo: To think of Pakistan as a homogeneous entity is a big mistake. You have to recognise that Pakistan is much more than that, more than the traditional stereotype of the army, the *mullahs* and the agencies. We need to deal with the ISI in multiple ways. There is an urgent need to develop capacities to be able to strike offensively against elements that are perpetrating terrorism. Someone once said that when you carry a big stick, you can speak softly. India carries a toothpick and shouts from the rooftop. There is a civil society in Pakistan which is interested in peace and also the business community. We cannot deal with them wearing the same spectacles. I think there are incentives, proactive incentives in fact, that we need to provide to that civil society to be able to make

it stronger so that it becomes more articulate, even though we might recognise the marginal role they play today in the establishment in Pakistan.

Finally, I think we need to work with our allies and try to put pressure on Pakistan. I believe we also need to start a dialogue. Not having one does not serve anything except certain electoral interests.

Kapil Kak: We need to understand that Pakistan is a Yugoslavia in the making. I believe this is a transformational moment for India and Pakistan and the initiative lies with us. We need to take a strategic leap of calculated, calibrated faith with regards to Indo-Pak policy. We need to have a selective engagement at one level and containment in a very focussed area. The Pakistan Army and the ISI are at the

centre of gravity of Pakistan and they are going to be there for next 15 years. So, I think if we make that differentiation and do engage with the rising civil society in Pakistan, we might get the strategic and political outcome we are seeking. Secondly, while the ISI and our intelligence agencies must meet, we should also look at military-to-military engagement. Besides I agree with the view that Sharm el-Sheikh was one of the steps towards that strategic leap of faith that I was talking about. It was badly handled in terms of not preparing the nation, Parliament and policymakers, but I think we need to move forward on a track which we have not followed for the last 62 years. When it comes to Pakistan, the possibilities are endless.

Brahma Chellaney: This is the question we were debating 20 years ago

